

Going Digital



Class 8 · Wednesday, September 23, 2026

Tonight

- High-Contrast Drawings due (submit in Brightspace)
- File prep and production literacy
- Going digital: from sketch to vector
- Tidy files: organizing and delivering your work
- Studio time: start digitizing

File Prep & Production Literacy

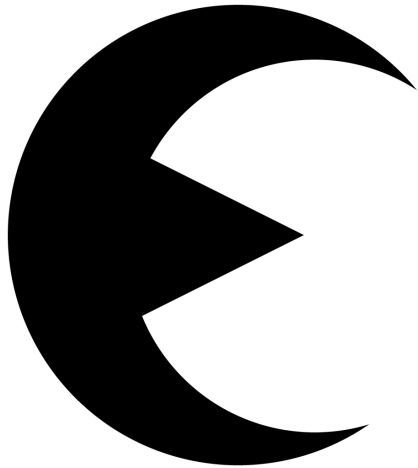
Why This Matters

- You may already know this, but we'll cover it again anyway
- Bad file prep costs you time, and it costs you credibility
- Clients and printers expect this without being asked
- Learn it now, use it for the rest of the semester

Vector vs. Raster

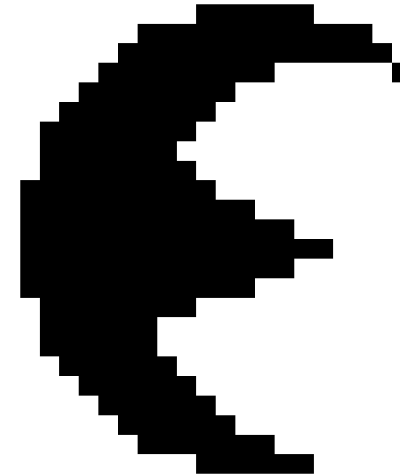
Same mark, zoomed in. Logos are vector. Always.

VECTOR



Built from math. Scales to any size, no loss.

RASTER



Built from pixels. Breaks down when scaled up.

Correct File Formats

VECTOR: MATH, INFINITELY SCALABLE

- AI: your working file
- PDF: print and sharing
- EPS: older print shops still ask for it
- SVG: websites and apps

RASTER: PIXELS, RESOLUTION SET BY PPI

- JPEG: photos and web, no transparency
- PNG: web and screens, transparent background
- Never hand off a logo as ONLY a JPEG

Color Spaces

RGB (AND HEX)

- Screens: web, social, video
- Additive: light, mixes toward white
- Widest gamut: the brightest colors
- Printed as RGB: colors shift and dull

CMYK

- Print: cards, brochures, packaging
- Subtractive: ink absorbs light, mixes toward black
- Smaller gamut: some screen colors can't print
- Not for screens

PANTONE (SPOT)

- Print: one premixed ink per color
- The most exact, consistent match
- Reaches colors CMYK can't: neons, metallics
- Costly past about three colors

One More Thing: Pantone

- Pantone libraries are no longer bundled in Adobe apps
- Free Pantone Connect account: look up any Pantone color and its number
- Paid Pantone Connect account: Use libraries inside Adobe apps
- Don't pick Pantone colors on a screen: use a Pantone swatch book

Every Mark Needs Versions

Design in black first. If it works in one color, it works.

- Full color
- Two-color
- One-color (black)
- Reversed (white on dark)

Lockups & Variations

You'll build these in Define. Know they're coming.

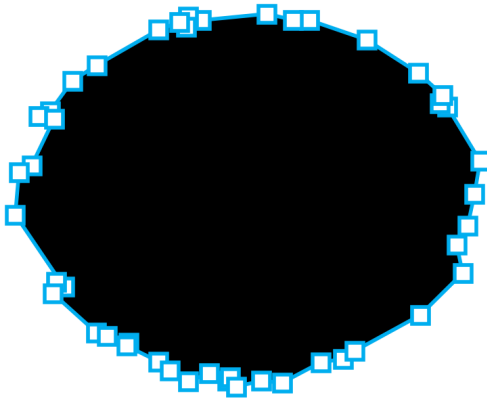
- Horizontal and vertical
- Mark alone, logotype alone
- With and without a tagline

Going Digital

Rule #1: No Image Trace

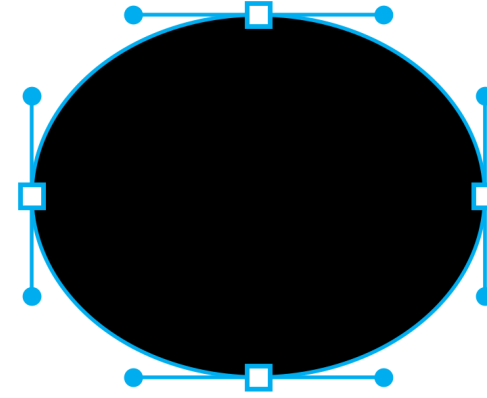
Image Trace gives you lumpy curves and dozens of points. Rebuild it by hand.

IMAGE TRACE



46 anchor points, wobbly edges

REBUILT BY HAND



4 anchor points, smooth curve

The Process

- Scan or photograph your drawing, flat and straight on
- Place it in Illustrator on a template layer, dimmed and locked
- Rebuild with shapes first, then the pen tool
- Hide the sketch and judge the mark on its own
- Duplicate, and keep refining

Build With Shapes

- Circles, rectangles, polygons as your base
- Shape Builder and Pathfinder to combine and cut
- Consistent geometry reads as intentional

Pen Tool Basics

- Anchor points at the extremes of a curve
- Keep handles horizontal or vertical (hold Shift)
- Fewest points possible
- New to the pen tool? Practice at bezier.method.ac
- No AI, Firefly, or plug-ins to digitize: learn to do this yourself

Type in Your Mark

- Start from a real typeface, then make it yours
- Adjust spacing by eye, not by default
- Practice kerning at type.method.ac
- Create Outlines to edit letterforms (more on fonts in a minute)

You're Still Sketching

- Iterate fast, and do it a ton!
- Get it to good, duplicate the artboard, keep editing
- Messy working files are fine for now
- Keep every version for your process book

Check Your Work

- Shrink it: does it hold up at half an inch?
- Black only, then reversed
- Compare to your sketch: did it lose something or is it better and evolving?

Tidy Files

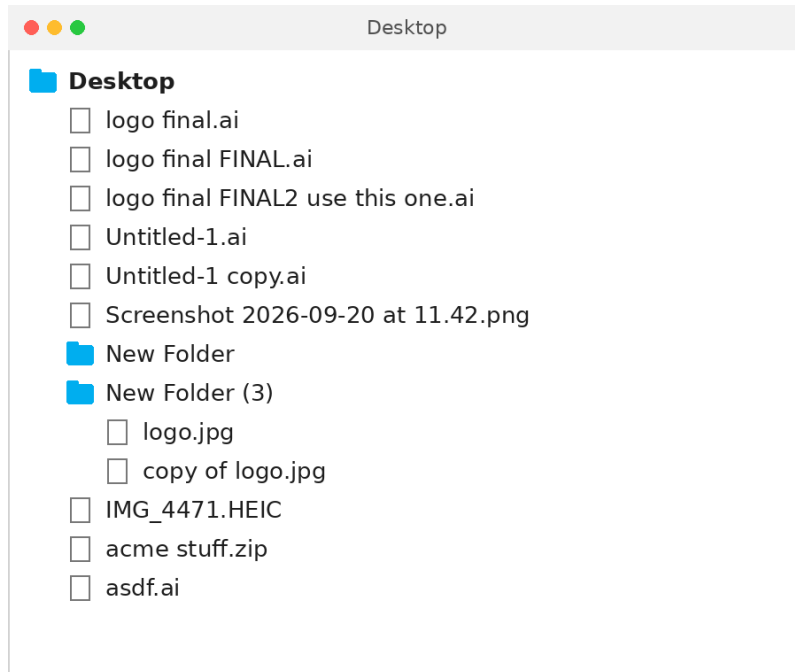
The 90% Rule

At any point, another designer should be able to step in and know what they're picking up, with 90%+ certainty.

- Folders that explain themselves
- File names that say what's inside, with a version number
- Layers that are named, grouped, and locked
- Screenshots of your folders and layers are required in your process book

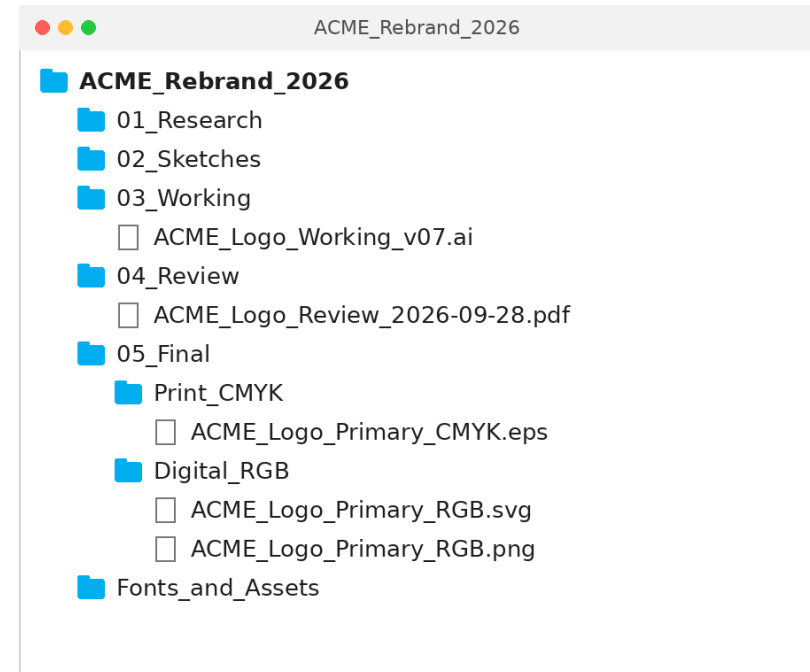
Folders & File Names

MESSY



Which one is final? Nobody knows, including you.

TIDY



Numbered stages, versioned names, print and digital split.

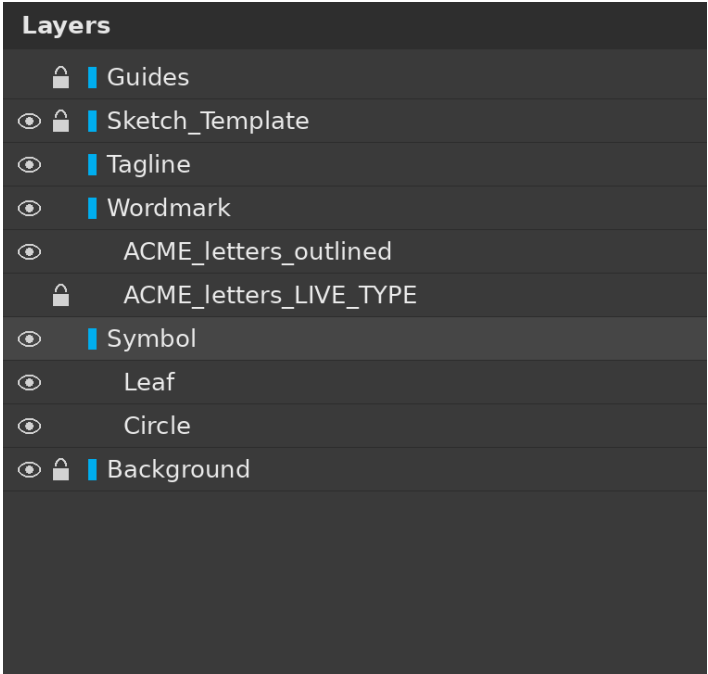
Layers

MESSY



Default names, hidden leftovers, "old stuff dont use."

TIDY



Named layers, sketch and guides locked, live type kept hidden.

Working File vs. Review File

WORKING FILE: YOUR SKETCHBOOK

- Messy is fine, iterate freely
- Duplicate artboards, keep every version
- Live type, sketches, experiments

REVIEW FILE: POLISHED

- Only what's being shown, nothing extra
- Named layers and artboards
- Anyone can open it and get it immediately

Fonts & Outlines

- Keep type live while you design, so you can still edit it
- Outline once the type is final, before review or delivery
- Keep a live-type copy on a hidden layer in your working file
- Never deliver live fonts: the client doesn't have them

Before It Leaves Your Hands

Every review, not just the final. Delivered files should be spotless.

- No stray points, empty layers, or hidden leftovers
- No abandoned pieces sitting off the artboard
- Fonts outlined, strokes expanded
- Unused swatches and symbols deleted
- Layers and artboards named
- Required in your process book: a screenshot of your final lockup in Outline mode

Tonight: Studio Time

- Digitize your preferred concepts, as many as you want, for both businesses
- Don't forget sketches you may still want to revisit
- Digitizing will eliminate some “good” sketches and elevate some “bad” ones: don't narrow yet
- Set up your folder structure tonight
- I'll check in around the room, wave me over

Coming Up

- Mon Sep 28: in-progress digitization check-in, small group feedback
- Week 6: Phase 2 kickoff and Personal Identity lectures
- Week 7: style-scapes, lockups, color and typography
- Wed Oct 14: System Definition due, two directions
- Mon Oct 19: narrow to one direction
- Dates subject to change, I'll keep the website up to date as we go

Questions?

Let's get digitizing.